

DeepThought Assignment

Contains -

Part A – Diagnosis

Part B – Intervention Design

Part C – Scale Thinking

Part D - Hand Drawn Diagram

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I may or may not be selected but , I believe great ideas create impact when turned into action.

pArT 1: DiAGnosiS

Situation 1 - THE ALERT NOBODY RESPOND TO

Stated problem - The daily alert email was sent every morning, but the CEO is getting the same RED alert. Anil and Karthik say that they send the report every day, but people do not take action. The CEO says that he still does not have visibility.

Underneath - the alert system is working, but there is no clear ownership. The alerts show department names, but they do not show the name of the person responsible for the task.

Basically It lacks ACCOUNTABILITY(nobody feels personally accountable for solving the issue). This alert system only gives alerts ,it doesn't show what percentage of work is completed and who did that . That's why the CEO does not get updated with daily alert completed sections.

Specific evidence - The advisor pointed out that the tracker shows department names instead of individual names. The alert email also does not show who is responsible, what action has been taken, or whether the issue has already been escalated. The CEO also said that the same red items stay red for many days and nothing happens.

Situation B – THE BLANK FIELD

stated problem - Anil and Karthik believe that people are not disciplined enough to fill the root cause field in the deviation tracker.

Underneath - the real problem is not lack of discipline. The real problem is FEAR. Supervisors are afraid that if they write the actual root cause, they will be BLAMED or QUESTIONED in meetings. Because of this, they leave the field blank or write vague answers instead of the real reason.

Specific evidence - One supervisor said that if he writes the real reason, people ask many questions and it becomes a blame game. Another supervisor said that when a real root cause was written earlier, a maintenance head was publicly called out. After that, people stopped writing honest root causes. This shows that employees do not feel safe sharing the truth

Situation C - THE MEETING THAT EATS THE DAY

stated problem - The daily status meeting is scheduled for 30 minutes usually runs for 60–90 minutes. Technical issues are discussed during the meeting , and create more work for the rest of the day.

Underneath - This is not mainly a meeting problem. It is a planning problem. The company has monthly and weekly plans, but there is NO DAILY PLANNING SYSTEM (Planned work and unplanned work are not separated) because of this, every issue is brought into the daily meeting, and the meeting becomes fighting sessions instead of status update meeting.

Specific evidence - The advisor asked for a daily plan and found that no daily plan existS there. The advisor also noted that no one was tracking routine work, planned work, and unplanned work separately. Technical issues that should be discussed elsewhere were being discussed in the daily status meeting, causing the meeting to become much longer than planned and takes lots of time.

pART 2: InterVENtion DeSIGN

Situation 1 - THE ALERT NOBODY RESPOND TO

My first conversation - Before talking I will observe department heads and supervisors some days, knowing their pattern of working and how they respond to daily alerts(Only having conversation fully can't help me to decide what's in their mind and what they are actually giving reason, then I can ask cross questions). After that I will talk to 2-3 department heads and supervisors.

I would ask: "When you see a red item in the morning email, what do you usually do next?"

Then I would listen carefully to understand how each team member responds to alerts and who is expected to take action. After that, I would ask: "Who do you think should be responsible when a task turns red?"

My goal is to understand whether the problem is with the alert itself or with ownership and accountability.

The actual intervention - I will redesign the alert to assign, not just report. I would also introduce a simple escalation rule. If a task stays red for more than a few days, it must be discussed with the next level of management. My focus will be on creating ownership before changing any technology. The CEO will now see:

- Task Name
- Owner Name
- Status
- Days Overdue
- Last Action Taken

Now the information goes into a shared tracker. If the task remains overdue, the system automatically highlights it with details.

Technology - Excel + Power Automate (Many company already uses Excel, so adoption will be easier)

Conclusion - With all these changes (everyone knows who owns the task, how much is completed, last action taken), so that the same issue does not come back every day.

Situation 2 - THE BLANK FIELD

My first conversation - I will speak separately with supervisors and team members who fill the deviation tracker. I will ask -

- What happens when someone writes the real root cause?
- Why do people leave the field blank?
- What happens if they write the real cause?is they get feared from someone?

Some of them will be experienced and working from many days I can ask deep question "How long it had been happening?" I need them to say it personally, in their words, because I will be the person who listens to them, not someone who came in with a preformed solution.

The goal is to make people feel safe sharing the truth. That trust is the intervention.

The actual intervention - They team members will now see a simple root cause form that focuses on solving the problem, not blaming people.

The new form would include:

- What happened?
- What is the main issue?
- Which departments are involved?
- What support is needed?
- Since when has this issue existed?
- How many days may be needed to solve it?
- What action has already been taken?
- How can we prevent this from happening again?

The form would not ask for the name of the person responsible. Instead, it would focus on understanding the problem and finding a solution.

During review meetings, the discussion would be problem-oriented rather than blame-oriented. The focus would be on fixing the issue and improving the process, not on identifying or criticizing individuals.

Technology- Excel or Google Forms (they are simple and familiar).

Situation 3 - THE MEETING THAT EATS UP THE DAY

My first conversation - This time I would talk to each member that joined the meeting Anil, Karthik, and a few department heads.

I would ask:

- What topics take the most time in the meeting?
- Which issues could be handled outside the daily meeting?
- How do you currently plan your day?
- So how do you decide, in the morning, what to focus on first?"

The actual intervention - I listen and find the pattern. Basically I can discover common things like

- Nobody has a daily plan,
- Everyone decides priorities differently.
- Technical discussions take 40–50 minutes.
- Meeting creates new tasks every day.

Now Before the daily meeting each person would get only 2–3 minutes for updates. If a technical issue needs a detailed discussion, it would be moved to a separate problem-solving meeting with only the relevant people.

I would also ask department heads to write down their top three priorities for the day. This would help the team understand what work was planned and what work was unexpected.

At the end of the week, I would review the unplanned issues and identify the most common reasons behind them, such as machine breakdowns or approval delays. This would help the company reduce firefighting and improve planning.

Technology- simple Excel/PDGMS sheet (for daily planned/unplanned task updates).

pART 3: Scale thinKING

- What breaks first when the company grows from 2 projects to 8 projects?

As the company grows, tasks increase a lot but the company depends too much on Anil and Karthik for follow-ups and coordination.

at present, they spend a lot of time reminding people, collecting updates, and creating coordination in the company. This may work with 2 projects, but it will not work with 8 projects. As the number of projects increases, they will spend all their time chasing updates instead of improving systems and solving problems.

Another issue is that tasks are assigned to departments rather than individuals. With more projects running at the same time, it will become difficult to know who is responsible for each task.

- What system would I build now?

I will build a simple ownership and planning system.

Every task should have:

- A clear owner
- A due date
- A status
- An escalation path

I would also encourage department heads to update their own daily plans and task status to make the system easier to manage as the company grows.

- What would I automate and what would I keep human?

I would automate:

- Daily status reports
- Alert emails
- Reminder notifications
- Escalation alerts
- Trend and performance reports

I would keep human:

- Root cause discussions
- Problem-solving conversations
- Coaching and supporting supervisors
- Decision-making
- Building trust between departments

Conclusion – Automation would handle repetitive tracking work, while people should focus on communication, judgment, and solving complex problems.

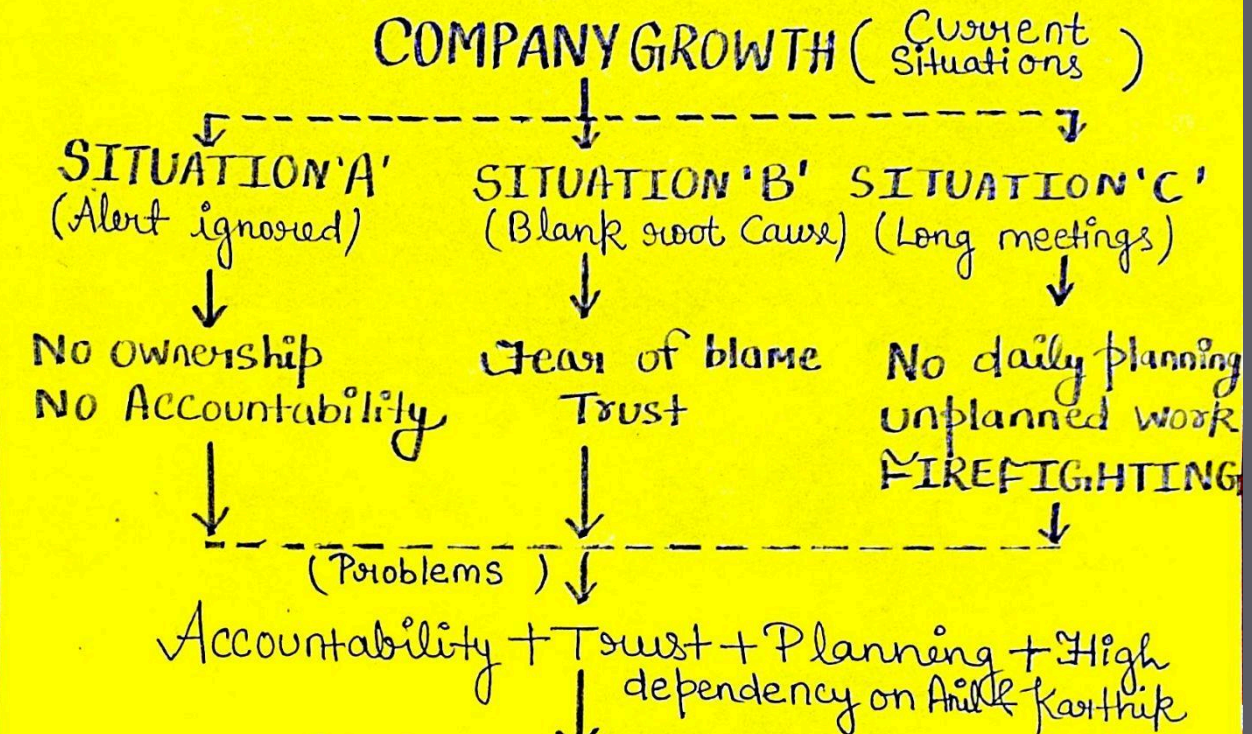
THANK YOU

(I spent a lot of time thinking and writing this assignment and completing it. It was a valuable learning experience for me.

I hope my submission is reviewed by humans not AI.)



DEEP THOUGHT



My Intervention

- **OWNERSHIP** - Every task has a named owner, due date & Status.
- **TRUST** - Blame-free environment, focus on problems, not person.
- **DAILY PLANNING** - Each HOD must prepares daily plan:
 - Planned
 - Unplanned
 - Routine work
- **ESCALATION** - Clear paths to follow.
- **MEETING DESIGN** - Daily: updates only

"OBSERVE"
UNDERSTAND
IMPROVE

RESULT

- Automate repetitive work.
- Continuous Review and Improvement.
- No blame games, people just report honestly.
- Time Saved, better meetings
- Ready to Scale. (2 → 8+ projects)

Technical: Separate meetings +
SHORT and FOCUSED

By Swarnima
Srivastava
(A Learner
inspired by
Deep Thought)

